Policy Memo Grading Rubric

INTL-I 522 Global Development · Final Project, Option 1 · Fall 2026

Each row is one component of the memo, weighted as shown. Find the cell that best describes your memo on that component; that cell is the grade for that component. A memo can earn an A on one row and a C on another. One question runs through every row: could a busy decision-maker take in the first page and the headings, understand the problem and your recommendation, and act on it?

Component	**A** Excellent	**B** Good	**C** Fair	**D** Poor	**F** Missing / fails
Formatting 10% *Fonts, margins, heading, page numbers as specified; in-text citations present and correct; bibliography in APSR format.*	Every formatting specification met exactly. Every claim that needs support is cited. In-text citations and bibliography follow APSR style consistently, with at most a trivial slip.	Specifications met with one or two minor lapses (e.g., missing page numbers, an off-spec heading). Citations present throughout, with a handful of APSR inconsistencies.	Several departures from the specified format. Some claims lack citations, or citations and bibliography are inconsistent or not in APSR style.	Specified format largely ignored. Citations sparse; bibliography incomplete or in a different style throughout.	Specified format not followed; citations or bibliography missing.
Organization & Style 30% *BLUF; introduction (problem, roadmap, summary of recommendations); conclusion; section headings that tell the story; bullets, tables, and bolding; clean, formal, plain-English prose.*	**BLUF:** the first lines state the problem and the recommendation; a reader could stop there and act. Introduction defines the problem, gives a roadmap, and previews recommendations; conclusion pulls the threads together. **Headings** tell the memo's story on their own. Bullets, tables, and bold are used purposefully to make key facts and asks easy to find. Prose is error-free, formal, jargon-free, and confident (first person is fine).	**BLUF** present and clear but wordy, or placed after background. Introduction and conclusion present, but one element is thin (e.g., no roadmap). Headings are generic (“Background,” “Analysis”) rather than telling the story. Formatting aids used unevenly. A few errors, or patches of jargon or academic register.	**BLUF** vague, missing the recommendation, or buried. Introduction or conclusion missing or merely summarizes. Headings sparse or misaligned with content; reads like a seminar paper with headings added. Few formatting aids, or fragmented over-bulleting. Frequent errors; jargon or informal tone gets in the way.	No real BLUF; the reader must hunt for the point. Little discernible organization; formatting aids absent. Errors are pervasive and impede comprehension.	Not written as a memo; organization and prose prevent the reader from following the argument.
Statement of the Problem 20% *Grasp of the major issues and actors; scope of the problem; why this reader should care; why this reader can act.*	Defines a specific problem, not just a topic, with its scope and magnitude (who, where, how large, which direction it is trending). Identifies the key actors and their stakes. Makes explicit why this reader should care now and what levers the reader holds.	Problem accurately described and main actors identified, but scope is under-quantified, or why this reader / why now is implied rather than stated.	Describes a topic or general issue rather than a defined problem. Key actors missing or listed without their stakes. Little sense of urgency or of the reader’s capacity to act.	Problem confused, inaccurate, or too broad to act on. The reader’s relevance is not addressed.	No identifiable problem statement.

Component	**A** Excellent	**B** Good	**C** Fair	**D** Poor	**F** Missing / fails
Describing the Issues (body) 20% *Social science research and expert opinion (min. 15 sources, 7 by experts); competing positions of relevant actors; existing projects and proposals, including those that cut against the memo.*	Meets or exceeds the source requirement (15+, 7+ expert) and uses sources as evidence for specific claims rather than as decoration. Fairly characterizes the competing positions of relevant actors, including those the author rejects. Surveys existing projects and proposals, including ones that run against the memo's recommendations, and assesses what they show.	Source requirement met, but evidence is summarized more than deployed, or leans heavily on one type of source. Competing positions present but treated thinly or one-sidedly. Existing proposals mentioned but not evaluated, or contrary ones omitted.	Falls short of the source requirement, or relies mainly on news and advocacy sources. Competing positions caricatured or missing. Few existing initiatives discussed.	Thin evidence; mostly unsupported assertion. A single perspective. No discussion of existing efforts.	Body does not engage research, competing positions, or existing proposals.
Recommendations & Conclusions 20% *Clear position; addresses competing proposals and counterarguments; suited to the audience; plausible given resources and circumstances.*	Recommendations are specific, prioritized, and actionable: who does what, by when, with what resources. No doubt where the author stands. Anticipates the strongest counterarguments and competing proposals and answers them; acknowledges trade-offs and risks. Every recommendation is within the recipient's authority and plausible given budget, politics, and capacity.	Clear position, but some recommendations are general ("improve coordination") or lack cost and sequencing. Counterarguments acknowledged but answered briefly. Mostly within the recipient's reach, with one or two that belong to a different actor.	Position hedged, or lists options without choosing among them. Counterarguments not engaged. Recommendations aimed at the wrong actor or requiring resources or political conditions that are not plausibly available.	Recommendations vague, inconsistent with the analysis, or implausible.	No recommendations, or recommendations unrelated to the problem.

What the letter grades mean for a policy memo

"A" memos can be acted on. The BLUF tells a busy reader the problem and the recommendation in the first lines; the headings alone tell the story; the evidence is specific, well sourced, and fairly weighs competing views; and the recommendations are concrete, within the recipient's power, and defended against the strongest objections. The prose is tight, formal, and free of errors.

"B" memos meet the requirements of the assignment and show a solid grasp of the problem and the literature, but something holds them back from being usable as written: the bottom line is buried or wordy, evidence is summarized rather than put to work, opposing positions get short shrift, or recommendations are sound in spirit but too general to act on.

"C" memos show a limited grasp of the problem or the genre. They often read as a research paper with headings: long on background, short on a clear position. Recommendations are hedged, aimed at the wrong actor, or unrealistic; sourcing is thin; and errors or unclear phrasing make the memo harder to use.

"D" memos do not identify a clear problem or a clear recommendation, offer little evidence or analysis, and are carelessly executed, with weak structure and frequent errors.

"F" memos are missing major components, are not written as policy memos, or do not address a development problem.